

league with 64 wins in the regular season. The Knicks were merely third in the Eastern Conference, behind another upstart in the Detroit Pistons and another surprising performer in the Boston Celtics. Meanwhile, the Spurs, an upstart who had finished in the draft lottery in 2024-25, surprised everyone by finishing a strong second in the Western Conference, just two games behind at 62-20.

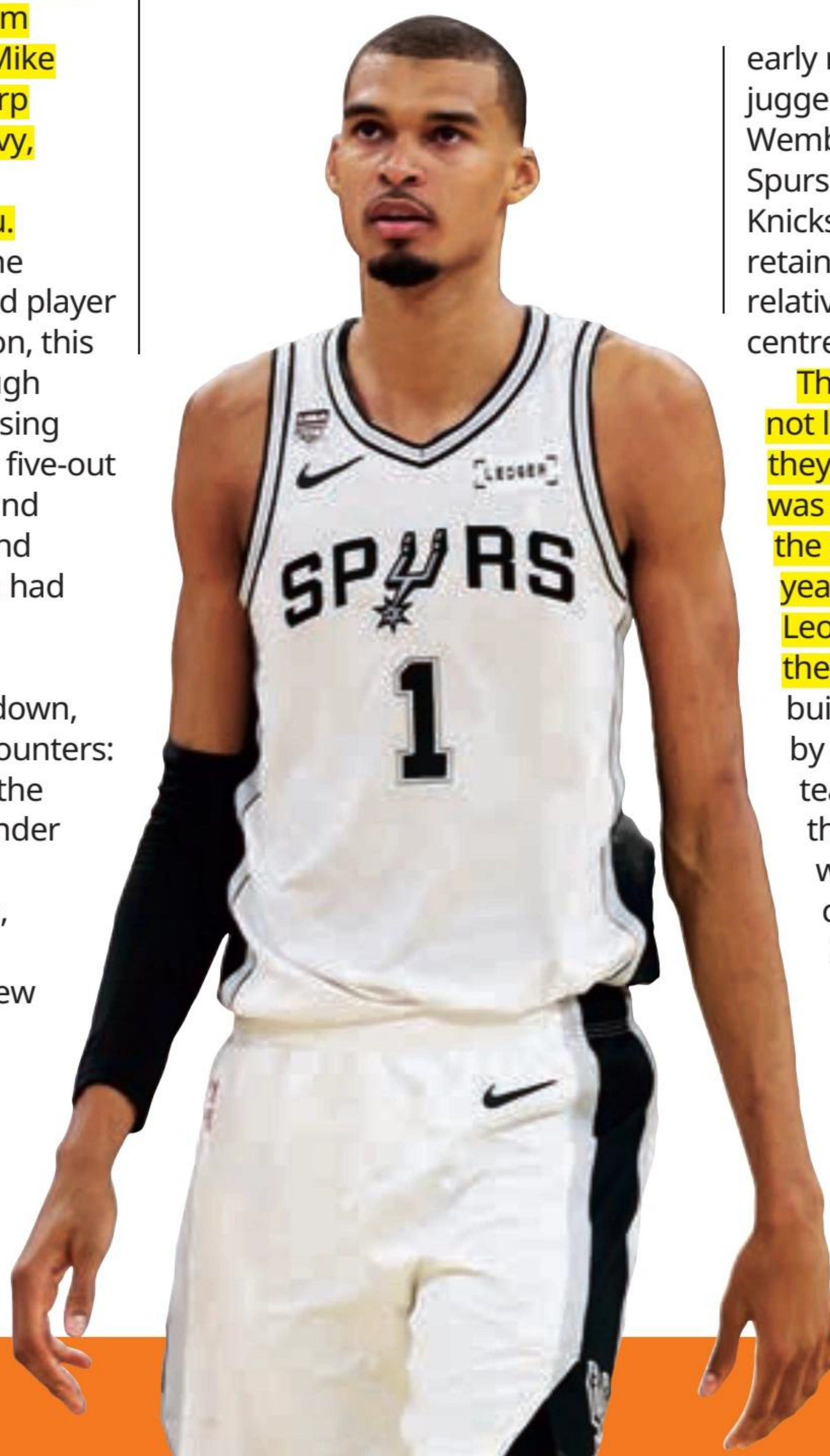
Former Spurs assistant coach Becky Hammon had emphatically argued that a team whose best player was as small as the 6 ft 1 in point guard Jalen Brunson could never win a title — a supposed structural defect in an era dominated by much taller wings, forwards and centres. Yet as the post-season wore on, the Knicks turned on the jets and began to dominate at both ends of the floor, with Brunson leading the way on offence and team-wide cohesion underpinning their defence.

The formula for the Knicks' success in the run-up to the Finals was the read-and-react system installed by first-year coach Mike Brown, which featured a sharp break from the isolation-heavy, slow-tempo offence of his predecessor, Tom Thibodeau. Brunson ran the point, but the engine was relentless ball and player movement. In the post-season, this movement also flowed through Karl-Anthony Towns as a passing hub at the top of the key in a five-out offence, reading coverages and feeding cutters off screens and handoffs — a scheme Brown had built in Sacramento around Domantas Sabonis.

When defences clamped down, the Knicks had two reliable counters: Brunson isolations, in which the shifty guard cooked his defender with footwork and midrange jumpers off screens and cuts, and Towns post-ups that punished single coverage. New York leaned into the Towns-based offensive hub only in the post-season, and it carried them through the



Cut above the rest: Karl-Anthony Towns (above) was the heart of the Knicks' five-out offence, which was also powered by the mercurial Jalen Brunson (left, No. 11). **Below:** Victor Wembanyama remained a cheat code for the Spurs, and won the league's Defensive Player of the Year trophy unanimously. PICS: GETTY IMAGES



early rounds. But this ran into a new juggernaut — the Victor Wembanyama-led San Antonio Spurs in the NBA Finals — where the Knicks had to improvise further to retain their edge after Towns was relatively neutralised by the 7ft 4in centre.

That said, the Knicks' success was not limited to off-the-shelf plays they used in the post-season. It was largely due to the chemistry in the squad, honed over the last few years ever since Knicks President Leon Rose took over the reins of the front office. He systematically built the squad around Brunson by recruiting his old college teammates — Brunson spent three seasons at Villanova, winning two national championships (2016 and 2018) and the 2018 national player of the year award before turning professional. These included the hard-working Josh Hart, one of the best rebounding